Key question
What did the 'road map' achieve?

Key dates

'Road map' to peace: 2003

Death of Yasser Arafat: 2004

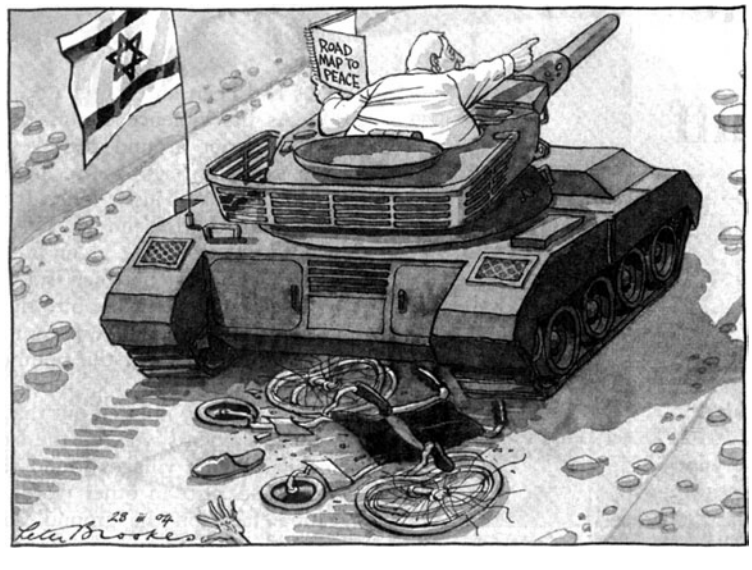
Mahmoud Abbas elected President of the Palestinian Authority: 2004

'Road map' to peace 2003

In April 2003 US President George W. Bush published what he called a 'road map' for peace between Israel and the Palestinians. His country was about to invade Iraq in order to topple the government of Saddam Hussein (see page 136) and he was keen to show he was just as concerned about the Palestinian problem as he was about oil-rich Iraq. The road map outlined a timetable for moves towards a Palestinian state. The first phase was to depend on an end to Palestinian bombings, to Israeli raids on Palestinian towns and to settlement building.

At first, the 'road map' made little difference. The Palestinian bombings continued and so did Israel's targeted assassinations. In March 2004, an Israeli helicopter missile killed the spiritual leader of Hamas as he left a mosque near his home in Gaza. However, over the next two years, there were signs of a revival in the peace process. In April 2004, the Israeli government announced that it would evacuate all Jewish settlers and troops from Gaza. In November 2004, Yasser Arafat died and was succeeded by Mahmoud Abbas who became Chairman of the PLO and was elected President of the Palestinian Authority. In February 2005, Abbas persuaded Palestinian militants to call a halt, even if only temporary, to their bombing. Then the Israeli and Palestinian leaders met in Egypt and announced a mutual ceasefire. In the summer of 2005, Jewish settlers and troops were withdrawn from Gaza.

Nevertheless, the issue of Jewish settlements on the West Bank remained the greatest obstacle to peace. For the peace process to succeed, trust between the two sides was necessary. Although Palestinian violence undoubtedly contributed to the breakdown of trust, the fundamental reason was the Israeli policy of expanding settlements on the West Bank. This policy was carried on under both hardline and more moderate Israeli governments and it prevented the emergence of a viable Palestinian state without which there could be no end to the conflict.



A cartoon from *The Times*, March 2004. It follows the killing of Hamas leader, Sheikh Ahmed Yassin, a paralysed man who had to use a wheelchair. In the tank is Israeli Prime Minister, Ariel Sharon. What is the message of the cartoon?